

Software Freedom Can Lead to Self-Reliance, says DeepRoot Linux Founder



Abhas Abhinav, founder of the Bengaluru based DeepRoot Linux, is an entrepreneur and hacker specialising in free software and hardware. For him, free and open source software (FOSS) is not just a professional choice, but a way of life that represents the very essence of personal freedom.

In an exclusive interview with OSFY, Abhas shares details about his initial encounter with FOSS and his subsequent free and open journey. Excerpts follow...

Q What were your initial thoughts when you experienced the FOSS phenomenon?

I didn't realise it was a phenomenon at that time. I first learnt to use bash, Perl and vi on a UNIX system over very slow (2400 baud) dial-up connections. These were the entry points for me to a very rich world of possibilities. I was using Windows (3.1 and then '95 and NT4), but soon I realised that there wasn't much to learn, do or program on Windows. And so I began exploring other operating systems such as OS/2 Warp and finally, GNU/Linux.

In 1998, I started using GNU/Linux full time after installing it on my desktop. I think it was a Red Hat

Q Can you recollect and share your first encounter with FOSS?

It must have been when I was still in school, back in 1994 or 1995 that I first began using some form of free software. I can remember two instances specifically.

I would use the console-based Lynx browser to access the Internet from a UNIX system in my father's office. Subsequently, I learnt to use vi and the UNIX command line too. In fact, I started liking Lynx so much that later on

(sometime in 1997/98) I programmed a DOS-based Web browser similar to Lynx using the Object Pascal programming language.

The second instance was when I learnt to use a tool called POV-Ray, which is a ray-tracer and can be used to design 3D graphics. The program came as part of a POV-Ray CD, which also had other tools such as modellers, viewers, animators and scene files that were designed and shared by other designers.